

C. Lab Help

Behold, you have not understood; you have supposed that I would give it unto you,
when you took no thought save it was to ask me.

But, behold, I say unto you, that you must study it out in your mind ..."

D&C 9:7-8

The Linux lab is staffed with lab assistants to provide support for students using the lab for computer science courses. Their major role is to provide assistance, support, advice, and recommendations to students. They are not to be considered a help desk where you bring a problem to them and expect them to solve it! As the semester progresses, lab assistants become increasingly busy and are not able to provide as much tutoring. Those struggling with a class or those that have been away from programming for a significant period (e.g. mission) are encouraged to sign up for class tutors from the tutoring center.

Lab assistants can be very useful when you have encountered a brick wall and just don't know how to proceed. They can help get you going again! You must put forth effort to complete your homework assignment. Do not expect lab assistants to give you answers or source code for your specific assignments. Instead, expect questions to guide you to a solution. For example they might say, "Have you tried using a while loop?", or "Are you sure you haven't exceeded your array bounds?", or "Check the syntax of your switch statement," or "Try putting some debug statements in your code *here* to see what is happening." With this kind of help you will understand what you have done wrong, you will be less likely to make this mistake in the future, and if this mistake is made in the future, you will be in a better situation to solve the problem without assistance. As a general rule, lab assistants are *not* allowed to touch the keyboard.

Lab assistants have been hired to help all students with general questions regarding use of the computers in the Linux lab. This includes, but is not limited to, difficulties with text editors, `submit`, `styleChecker`, `testBed`, `svn`, `PuTTY`, `winscp`, and simple operating system issues. CS 124 and CS 165 students should expect appropriate assistance from lab assistants. CS 235 students, particularly those who have been away for a couple of years, should also expect appropriate assistance from lab assistants during the first few weeks of the semester. Generally speaking, however, students should have learned how to help themselves and resolve their own problems by the time they have completed CS 235. CS 213 students may expect some help from the lab assistants.

Lab assistants are expected to give first priority to CS 124 and CS 165 students. Students in upper-division classes should not expect assistance from lab assistants.

To more effectively respond to questions, a "Now Serving" system has been setup in the lab which allows a student to click on an icon and it automatically places a request for help in a queue. The lab assistants monitor the queue and help the next student in the queue. It's like taking a number and waiting for your number to be called. However, instead of calling your number they just come to your machine. To use the "Now Serving" system you will need to ask the lab assistants to set it up for you the first time. Once initially setup an icon will be visible each time you login then you simply click on the Icon to make a request for help. You won't need to keep holding your hand up waiting for a lab assistant to see you, and it makes sure that you get help in the proper order. Please ask the lab assistants to show you how to use the "Now Serving" software so they can serve you better. Students in upper-division classes should not expect assistance from lab assistants